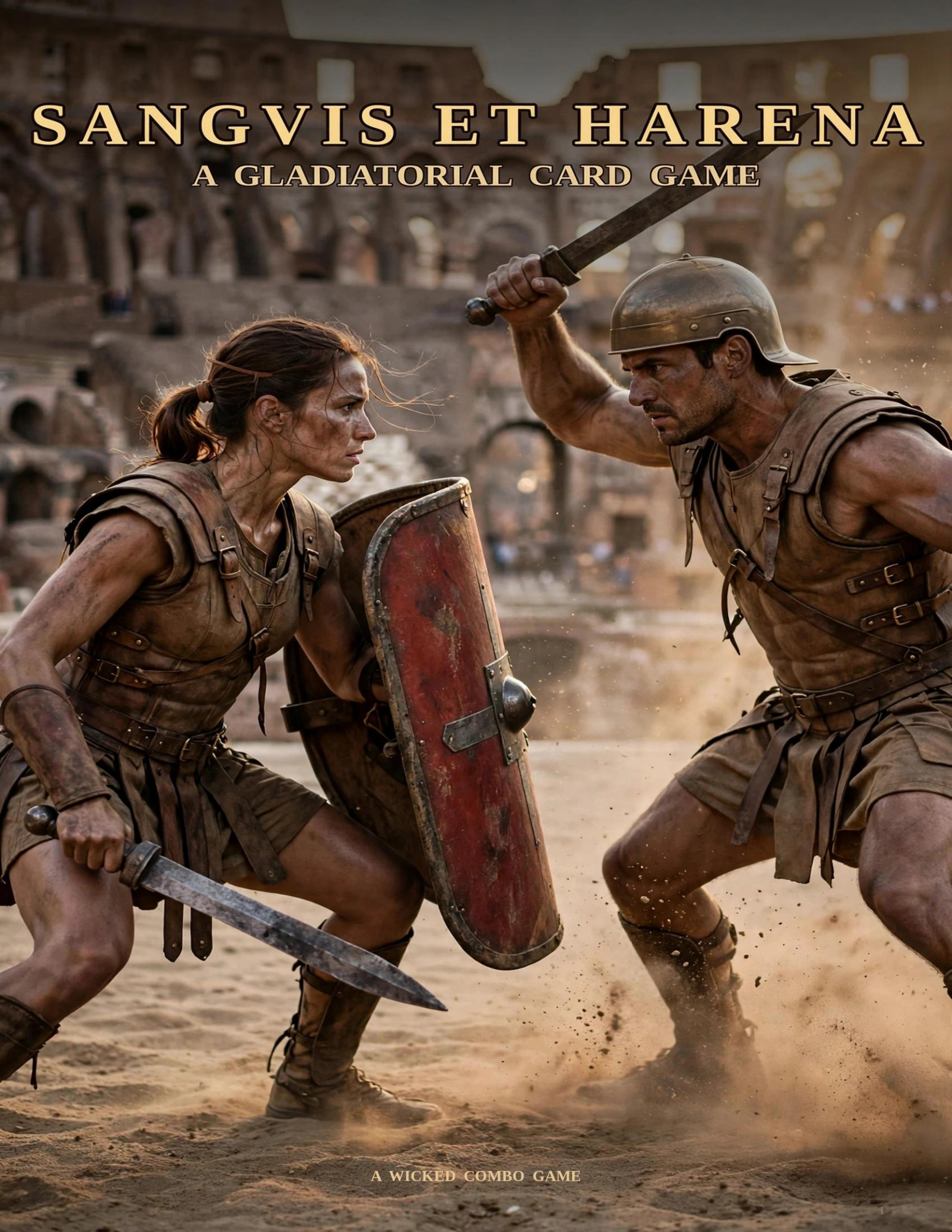
SANGVIS ET HARENA

A GLADIATORIAL CARD GAME



A WICKED COMBO GAME

Welcome to the Arena

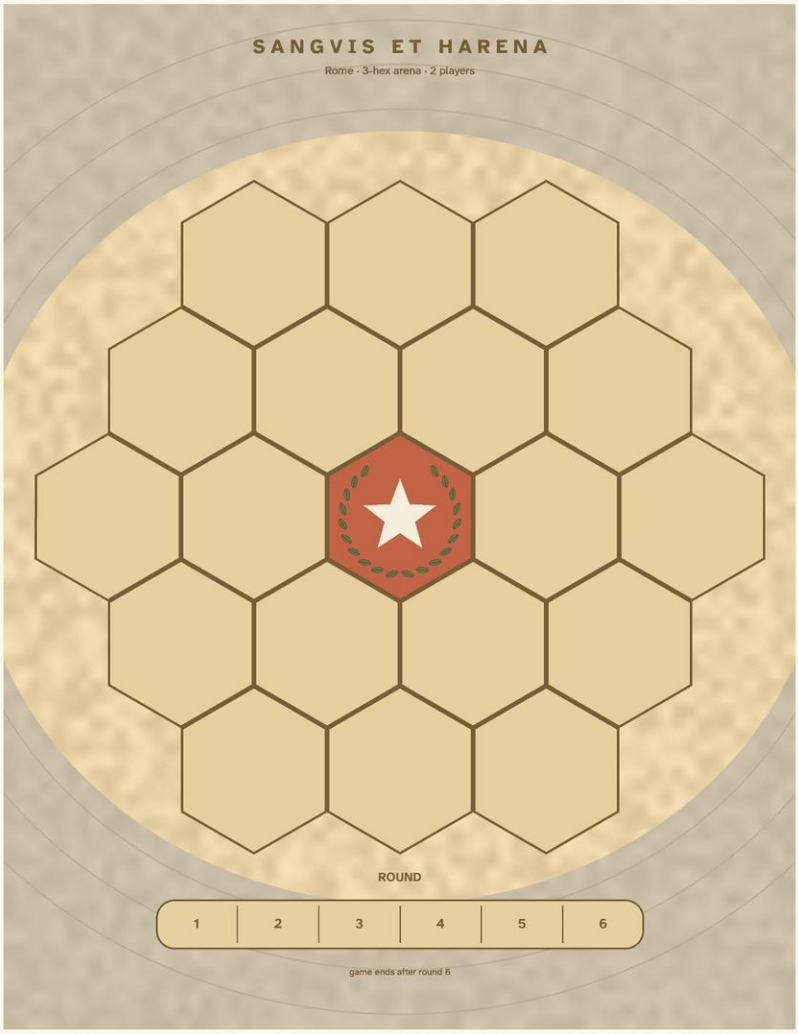
Sanguis et Harena — "blood and sand" — drops you into the gladiatorial arenas of ancient Rome. You are a champion fighter. Win the crowd. Stay alive.

If you've played Wingspan, Terraforming Mars, or any modern board game, you'll pick this up fast. The rules take five minutes to learn. Every fight is different.

What You Need

- One 36-card deck per player: 23 action cards, 9 gear cards, 4 champion cards
- The arena board (pick the size for your player count)
- 10 player aid cards — keep these handy for your first games
- Two player mats (one per player)
- Tokens for water, blood, and glory — coins or beads
- A figure or meeple per fighter to mark your position. We don't provide these — use a miniature, a wooden meeple, even a coin.

> **New to the game?**
>
> Play the basic game first (pages 3–7). The advanced rules on pages 8–9 add facing and weapon arcs for deeper tactics — but the basic game is complete on its own.



The 2-player arena — larger arenas for 3–6 players included

Goal & Setup

The Goal

Entertain the crowd. After 6 rounds, the fighter with the most glory wins.

If a fighter's blood hits zero, they're eliminated. Last one standing wins immediately.

Setup

- Each player takes their own 36-card deck. Choose your champion from your 4 champion cards (both players may pick the same champion).
- Set water, blood, and glory tokens to your champion's starting values.
- Choose your loadout (see below): weapons, shields, and armor for your hands, arms, and head.
- Place fighters on opposite sides of the arena.
- Pick a starting player randomly — they get the first player marker.

Your Loadout

Pick weapons and shields for your hands, armor for your arms and head. Weapons determine how much blood your attacks spill. Armor costs water every round — shed it between rounds if you're running dry.

- Weapons: Gladius, Sica, Trident, Net
- Shields: Scutum, Parma
- Armor: Manica (arm), Galea (heavy helm), Cassis (light helm)



Rufus, ready for the arena: Gladius in the right hand, Scutum in the left

How a Round Works

Each round has 6 seconds. Every second follows five steps:

> **CHOOSE → SHOW → ACT → BURN → REPEAT**
>
> This is the heartbeat of the game. You'll do this 36 times per game — it becomes second nature fast.

CHOOSE

Secretly pick one card from your hand. Hold it face-down. Say "ready" when everyone has chosen.

SHOW

Everyone reveals at once. Place your card on the burn-down track in the column matching its heat: 1, 2, or 3 fire icons.

ACT

In player order (starting with the first player), each player takes their turn. Every card on your burn-down track is active — take their actions in any order, and skip any you don't want.

If you're at the arena edge, you can spend the second to rally (refill water) or change your loadout instead of acting.

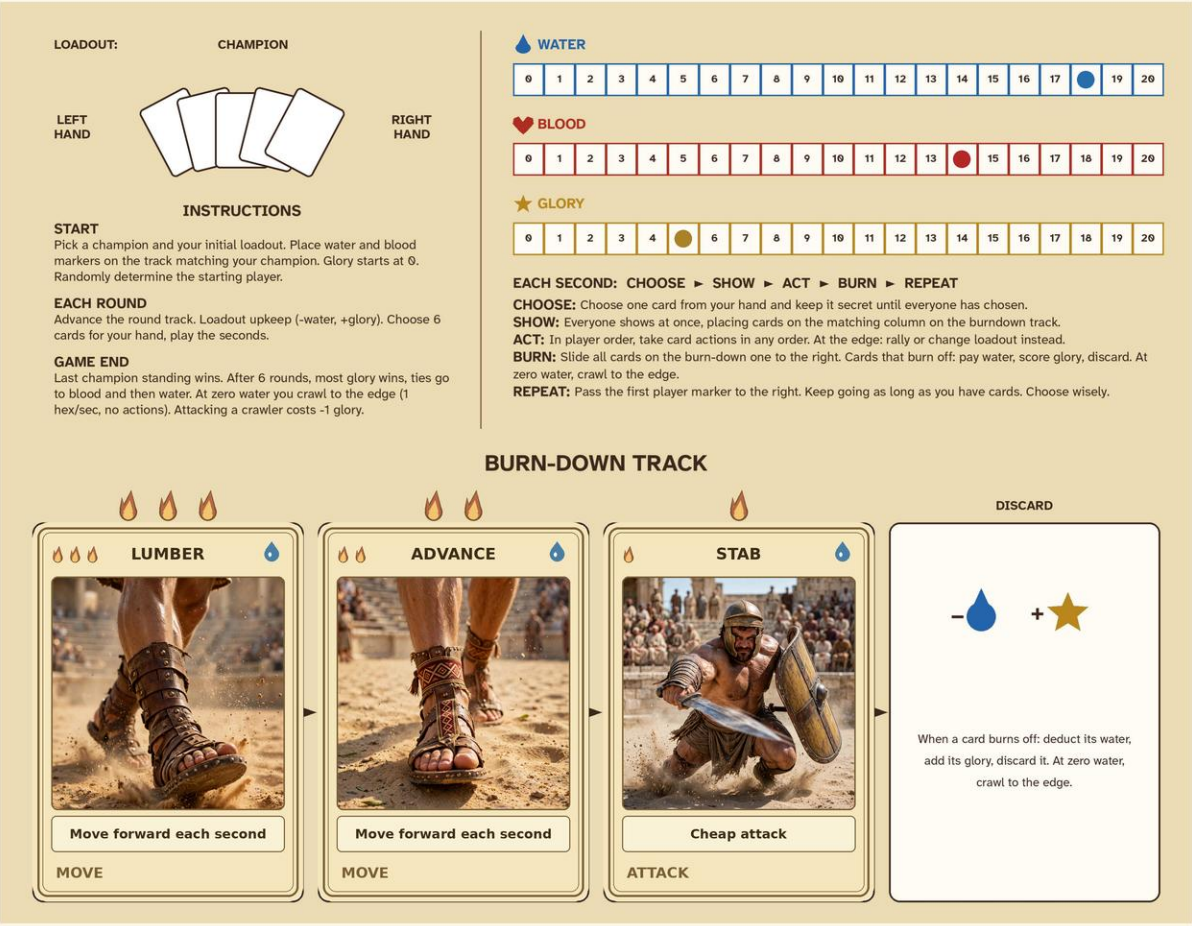
BURN

Slide all cards on the track one step right. Cards that fall off: pay their water cost, score their glory, discard them.

Then check your water. If it's at zero, you start crawling — see page 6.

REPEAT

Pass the first player marker right. Next second!



Your mat mid-round: cards burning down, markers on the tracks

The Cards

Five types. Here's what they do:

Movement

Quick Step, Retreat, Sidestep, Advance, Lumber, Circle, Wheel. Get around the arena. Some are quick, some cover ground, some spin you around.

Attacks

Stab, Sottano, Fendente, Redoppio. Each pairs with your weapon. Your weapon — not the card — determines how much blood you spill.

Defense

Duck, Dodge, Jump, Parry. Avoid or block attacks. Duck evades high attacks. Jump evades low attacks.

You can also block with gear. When you're attacked, you may block with a shield or armor piece — your choice, each attack. Each blocked attack puts 1 dent on that gear (scutum 4, parma 2, manica 3, galea 4, cassis 3 dents to break). Broken gear gives no defense. Net attacks can be blocked like any other attack.

Flourishes

Spinta, Molinello, Salute, Kip-Up. Showy moves that earn glory. Kip-Up also pops you back up when you're prone.

Combos

Lunge (move then attack), Ritirata (attack then move), Riposte (defend then attack), Kron (defend with style). Two actions, one card.



Top row: one of each type. Bottom row: more of the deck

Water, Glory & Prone

Water — Your Fuel

Every card costs water (droplets, top-right corner). You pay when the card burns off — not when you play it.

Crawling — Out of Water

When BURN leaves your water at zero, you start crawling. You're exhausted, dragging yourself toward the edge for relief.

- All your remaining hand cards become crawl: move one hex per second toward the nearest arena edge.
- No attacks, defenses, or flourishes while crawling — but you still play one card each second.
- At the edge, rally: spend one second to refill your water to your champion's rally value.
- You can also change your loadout at the edge — that costs one second too.
- Attacking a crawler costs the attacker 1 glory. The crowd hates it.

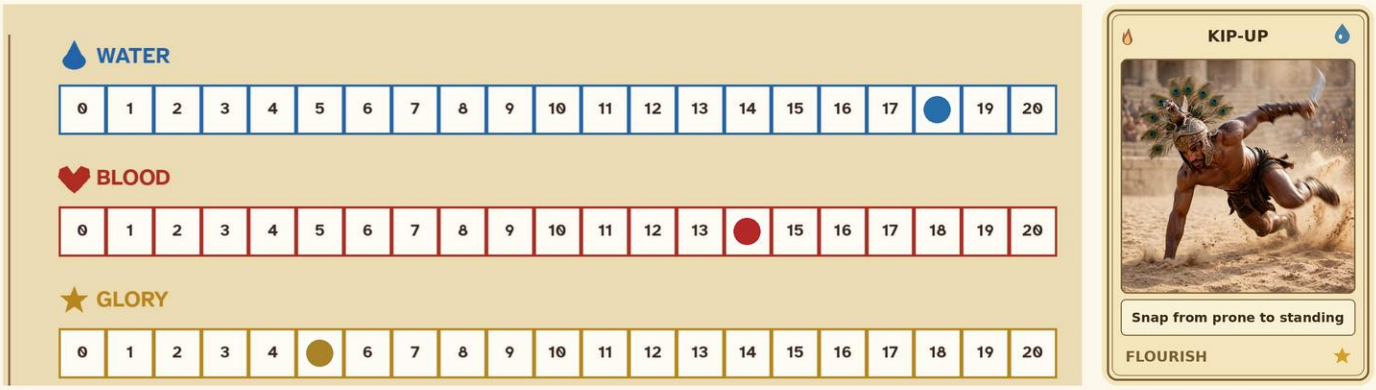
Glory — Your Score

Glory is stars (bottom-right corner). You score it when cards burn off. Flashy cards earn more. Most glory after 6 rounds wins.

Going Prone

Take 3+ blood in one second and you're knocked flat. You waste your next second standing up — no actions. Kip-Up negates prone instantly.

> **Kip-Up cancels prone!**
>
> Knocked flat? Play Kip-Up and snap straight back to standing — no wasted second. It's the only card that skips the stand-up, and it earns glory too.



Track your water, blood, and glory — and keep a Kip-Up handy

The Champions

Four fighters. Four styles. Each has a special ability usable once per round.

Rufus the Ox

"Rufus once headbutted a gate. The gate apologized."

The brute. Once per round: Stab as an additional action.

Vela the Eel

"She moves like a reed in the wind."

The swift. Once per round: Move as an additional action.

Cassius the Peacock

"The crowd didn't come to see him win. They came to see him."

The showman. Once per round: +1 glory when you play a flourish.

Drusa the Wall

"Twenty rounds. Four scars. Zero apologies."

The veteran. Once per round: Parry as an additional action.



Rufus, Drusa, Cassius, Vela — pick your fighter

Advanced Rules

You've got the basics. These optional rules add tactical depth. The basic game is complete without them.

Facing

In the advanced game, your fighter has a facing — the direction they're looking. It matters for attacks and defenses.

Turn 60° for free at any time during your turn. The Wheel card turns you 120°.

Attack & Defense Arcs

Your weapon hits the hex directly ahead plus the hex on its hand's side. Your shield covers the hexes on its hand's side. The hexes behind you are always exposed.



Appendix: What's in a Name

Every name in this game comes from real history — Roman arms and armor, the Italian fencing masters, and Latin itself. Here's where they come from.

The Title

- Sanguis et Harena (SAHN-gwis et hah-REH-nah) — "blood and sand." Harena is Latin for sand: the sand strewn across the arena floor to soak up blood. Arena itself comes from harena.

The Steel — Roman Weapons

- Gladius (GLAH-dee-us) — the short sword of the Roman legionary, built for the thrust in close ranks.
- Sica (SEE-kah) — the curved blade of Thrace and Dacia, carried in the arena by the thraex gladiator.
- Trident & Net — the signature kit of the retiarius, the "net-man," who fought with trident (fuscina) and weighted net (rete), no helmet, no shield.

The Defense — Roman Armor

- Scutum (SKOO-tum) — the great curved rectangular shield of the legions.
- Parma (PAHR-mah) — the small round shield of light troops — and of the thraex in the arena.
- Manica (mah-NEE-kah) — the segmented arm guard. Gladiators wore it on the sword arm; the retiarius wore it on the exposed left.
- Galea (gah-LAY-ah) & Cassis (KAS-sis) — Latin for helmet, heavy and light. The cassis was the plain bronze cap with no crest — exactly what Rufus wears on his cards.

The Blows — the Fencing Masters

Our attack names come from the Italian masters — Fiore dei Liberi (c. 1409) and Filippo Vadi (c. 1482), whose fight-books catalogued the true cuts of the sword:

- Fendente (fen-DEN-tay) — the descending cut. Vadi's own verse: "We are the fendenti, the downward cuts, that start fights."
- Sottano (sot-TAH-noh) — the rising cut, thrown upward from below. One of Fiore's seven true blows.
- Redoppio (reh-DOH-pyoh) — the redoubled cut: strike, then strike again in the same breath. Named in the Bolognese tradition.
- Molinello (moh-lee-NEL-loh) — "the little mill." A wheeling circular cut, described by the Bolognese masters and given its own chapter by Alfieri (1653).
- Ritirata (ree-tee-RAH-tah) — the retreat: strike, then withdraw in good order. A formal term of the Italian salle.
- Salute (sah-LOO-tay) — the fencer's salute to opponent and crowd — which is exactly what it earns you: glory.

The Champions — Roman Names

- Rufus (ROO-fus) — a common Roman cognomen meaning "red-haired." Half the legions seemed to have one.
- Cassius (KAS-ee-us) — one of the great Roman gentes. A conspirator's name for a showman.
- Drusa (DROO-sah) — the feminine form of Drusus, a proud Roman cognomen borne by generals and emperors' kin.
- Vela (VEH-lah) — Latin for "sails." She moves like a reed in the wind; the name is our invention, but the Latin is real.

From Other Schools

Two cards honor fencing traditions beyond Italy:

- Kron (krohn) — German for "crown." In the Liechtenauer longsword tradition, the Kron is the crown guard — and the Kronhau, the crown hew, breaks strong cuts from above.
- Riposte (rih-POHST) — the French school's answer: the return thrust delivered in the same breath as the parry.

Credits

SANGUIS ET HARENA

A Wicked Combo game.

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Game design and development by Mark Davis.

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Card art is AI-generated placeholder. Final art from human artists planned.

Thank you for bleeding on the sand with us.

In memory of Norm Davis, who gave us the "Norm Maneuver."

Special thanks to Paul Davis, for saying "I want to build a gladiator game."

Special thanks to Clan McFavis, for the early playtests.

SanguisHarena.com

WickedCombo.com